

Psalms 104

A Hymn to the Creator

Bless the Lord, O my soul... O Lord my God, thou art very great
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Bless the LORD, O my soul. O LORD my God, thou art very great; thou art clothed with honour and majesty.
- 2 Who coverest thyself with light as with a garment: who stretchest out the heavens like a curtain:
- 3 Who layeth the beams of his chambers in the waters: who maketh the clouds his chariot: who walketh upon the wings of the wind:
- 4 Who maketh his angels spirits; his ministers a flaming fire:
- 5 Who laid the foundations of the earth, that it should not be removed for ever.
- 6 Thou coveredst it with the deep as with a garment: the waters stood above the mountains.
- 7 At thy rebuke they fled; at the voice of thy thunder they hasted away.
- 8 They go up by the mountains; they go down by the valleys unto the place which thou hast founded for them.
- 9 Thou hast set a bound that they may not pass over; that they turn not again to cover the earth.
- 10 He sendeth the springs into the valleys, which run among the hills.
- 11 They give drink to every beast of the field: the wild asses quench their thirst.
- 12 By them shall the fowls of the heaven have their habitation, which sing among the branches.
- 13 He watereth the hills from his chambers: the earth is satisfied with the fruit of thy works.
- 14 He causeth the grass to grow for the cattle, and herb for the service of man: that he may bring forth food out of the earth;
- 15 And wine that maketh glad the heart of man, and oil to make his face to shine, and bread which strengtheneth man's heart.
- 16 The trees of the LORD are full of sap; the cedars of Lebanon, which he hath planted;
- 17 Where the birds make their nests: as for the stork, the fir trees are her house.
- 18 The high hills are a refuge for the wild goats; and the rocks for the conies.
- 19 He appointed the moon for seasons: the sun knoweth his going down.
- 20 Thou makest darkness, and it is night: wherein all the beasts of the forest do creep forth.
- 21 The young lions roar after their prey, and seek their meat from God.
- 22 The sun ariseth, they gather themselves together, and lay them down in their dens.
- 23 Man goeth forth unto his work and to his labour until the evening.
- 24 O LORD, how manifold are thy works! in wisdom hast thou made them all: the earth is full of thy riches.
- 25 So is this great and wide sea, wherein are things creeping innumerable, both small and great beasts.
- 26 There go the ships: there is that leviathan, whom thou hast made to play therein.
- 27 These wait all upon thee; that thou mayest give them their meat in due season.
- 28 That thou givest them they gather: thou openest thine hand, they are filled with good.
- 29 Thou hidest thy face, they are troubled: thou takest away their breath, they die, and return to their dust.
- 30 Thou sendest forth thy spirit, they are created: and thou renewest the face of the earth.
- 31 The glory of the LORD shall endure for ever: the LORD shall rejoice in his works.
- 32 He looketh on the earth, and it trembleth: he toucheth the hills, and they smoke.
- 33 I will sing unto the LORD as long as I live: I will sing praise to my God while I have my being.
- 34 My meditation of him shall be sweet: I will be glad in the LORD.
- 35 Let the sinners be consumed out of the earth, and let the wicked be no more. Bless thou the LORD, O my soul. Praise ye the LORD.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 104 is an extended meditation on creation as ongoing, sustained provision rather than a finished, distant event—God is pictured actively clothing Himself with light, laying beams in the waters, feeding wild donkeys, timing the sun and moon, and sending forth His Spirit to renew the face of the earth continually. Henry treats it as a companion to Genesis 1, retelling the creation days poetically while emphasizing God's present, moment-by-moment sustaining care over every creature, not merely His initial act of making them.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

The psalm opens in wonder at God's own splendor: covered with light as with a garment, stretching out the heavens like a curtain, laying the beams of His chambers in the waters, making clouds His chariot and walking on the wings of the wind. Even angels and flames of fire are pictured as His messengers and servants—creation itself is His household staff.

Verse 5-9

The earth's foundations and the taming of the waters are recalled: laid so they would never be shaken, once covered by the deep as with a garment until God's rebuke sent the waters fleeing, mountains rising and valleys sinking into their appointed places. A boundary is set that the waters may not pass, so they will never again cover the earth—God's ordering of chaos into stable, dependable structure.

Verse 10-13

Provision flows naturally from that order: springs sent into valleys, running among the hills, giving drink to every beast of the field, satisfying the wild donkeys' thirst. Birds nest and sing among the branches nearby; God waters the hills from His chambers above, and the earth is satisfied by the fruit of His works.

Verse 14-18

Provision extends specifically to human life and to the wider animal world: grass grown for cattle, herbs for people to cultivate, food brought from the earth, wine to gladden the heart, oil to make the face shine, bread to strengthen. Trees are full of sap, cedars planted by God Himself; birds make nests there, storks find fir trees, wild goats find high hills, and rock badgers find shelter among the rocks—every creature is shown its own particular, deliberate provision.

Verse 19-23

God's ordering of time itself is celebrated: the moon appointed for seasons, the sun knowing its time to set. Darkness is made for the night, when every beast of the forest creeps out; lions roar for their prey, seeking their food from God. When the sun rises, they retreat to their dens, and man goes out to his labor until evening—day and night each given their own rhythm and purpose.

Verse 24-30

The sheer abundance and variety of God's works prompt direct praise—how manifold are they, made in wisdom, the earth full of His riches. The sea itself, great and wide, teems with innumerable creatures, ships passing through, even the great leviathan formed to play there. All creatures wait on God for their food in due season; when He gives, they gather it, filled with good; when He hides His face, they are troubled; when He takes away their breath, they die and return to dust; when He sends forth His Spirit, they are created anew, and the face of the earth is renewed—creation's dependence on God is continuous, not a one-time transaction.

Verse 31-35

The psalm closes in resolve: may the glory of the Lord endure forever, may He rejoice in His own works; He looks on the earth and it trembles, touches the hills and they smoke. The psalmist commits to singing to the Lord as long as he lives, finding his own meditation of Him sweet, resolving to rejoice in the Lord. The closing wish that sinners be consumed from the earth is paired with the psalm's own final refrain, addressed once more to his own soul: bless the Lord. Praise the Lord.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Creation is not a distant, finished event but an ongoing relationship of dependence, in which every creature—from the smallest bird to the great leviathan—continually waits on God's present provision rather than surviving on some initial, one-time act of making. The same God whose glory fills the vast scale of sea, mountain, and sky is also the God who deliberately provides food, shelter, and rhythm for each individual creature, down to the rock badger and the wild donkey.

Application for life today.

Let this psalm expand your sense of God's care beyond your own immediate concerns—He is shown here attending to wild donkeys, storks, and rock badgers with the same deliberate specificity He gives to human need; consider what that means for whatever feels too small to bring to Him. Practice the psalm's ongoing dependence rather than a one-time gratitude: notice today's specific provisions (food, light, rhythm of work and rest) as evidence of God's present, continuing sustaining hand, not just His distant original act of creation. Let verse 34's resolve—finding meditation on God genuinely sweet—shape a specific, unhurried time this week simply to notice and enjoy what He has made.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. How does seeing God's deliberate provision for creatures as small as rock badgers and wild donkeys (vv. 11, 18) change what you think is 'too small' to bring to Him?

2. What specific provision in your life today—food, rhythm of work and rest, shelter—could you notice as evidence of God's ongoing sustaining care rather than take for granted?

3. What would it look like to set aside unhurried time this week to let meditation on God's creation be genuinely 'sweet' to you, as verse 34 describes?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).